

The Impact of Bullying on the Mental Health and Well-being of Black Youth in Ontario:

An Exploratory Descriptive Qualitative Systematic Narrative Review Study

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Research Methods: MHR884

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Student Declarations

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Declaration of Any Previous Submission of the Work

The material presented here for this current course is a continuation of the research study proposal presented in the prerequisite course MHR774 for the Honour's Bachelor in Mental Health and Addiction program at Seneca Polytechnic.

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DEDICATION

This research paper is dedicated to the memory of my late parent. My husband, my siblings for putting up with my stress throughout my years at Seneca Polytechnic and to everyone that stood by me while written this project. To the academia body referenced in this research report, I acknowledge the role of the academic institution of Seneca Polytechnic for the role they played in my academic journey.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

UBC - University of British Columbia

PoBC - Parents of Black Children

GoC - Government of Canada

HPA - Hypothalamic-Pituitary-Adrenal

WHO - World Health Organization

CIHR - Canadian Institutes of Health Research

SSHRC - Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada

ABSTRACT

The purpose of this Exploratory Descriptive Qualitative Systematic Narrative Review Study is to explore the impact of bullying on the mental health and well-being of Black youth in Ontario. This study attempts to disseminate valuable knowledge regarding implications of bullying and the need for adequate mental health supports for Black youth in Ontario. These youths represent a vulnerable group due to both their race and culture, a phenomenon otherwise known as Double Jeopardy (Millar and Brookes, 2021). Data was rigorously gathered using a descriptive qualitative systematic tool to explore the mental health presentations and the frequency with which Black youth encounter bullying as reflected in peer-reviewed articles. The outcomes of this study have the capacity to provide valuable insights for focused interventions, enhancement of supportive health systems and producing policy recommendations. The ultimate goal would be to enhance mental health care services and promote overall well-being of this marginalized population in Ontario.

Keywords: Bullying, Black Students, Mental Health, Suicide, Ontario.

1. Introduction

Contemporary Canadian society celebrates diversity as a core value that promotes inclusion, kindness, and leadership, which form the pillar of Canada's national identity (Fleras, 2019). Renowned globally for its commitment to fostering a multicultural landscape, Canada places a significant emphasis on health promotion, recognizing the significant impact of social determinants on individual well-being (Weldon & Hoffman, 2021). By extension, the province of Ontario serves as a representative of Canada's rich cultural diversity, shaped by increased immigration (Abawi, 2019). However, amidst this celebration of diversity and inclusion, a parallel reality persists – the prevalence of bullying, particularly among marginalized groups (Campbell, 2021). Among these groups are Black youth, who represent a demographic that has historically faced unique challenges, rooted in systemic inequities and social prejudices (Henderson et al., 2019). Understanding the impact of bullying on the mental health and well-being of Black youth in Ontario is not only important for addressing the immediate consequences but also for advancing a more inclusive and equitable society aligned with Canadian values (Cahil, Dadvand, & Gowing, 2021).

The landscape of contemporary Ontario reflects the outlook of Canada's multicultural society, shaped by successive immigration from every corner of the globe, which enriches Ontario's social and cultural environment, fostering a sense of belonging and community (Abawi, 2019). Nevertheless, within this vibrant progress, the rates of bullying overshadow the well-being of many, particularly ethnographically Black youth who struggle with intersecting identities and experiences of discrimination (Campbell, 2021).

Furthermore, historically, Canada has championed diversity and inclusion as fundamental principles, acknowledging the contributions of various ethnic, cultural, and racial groups to the nation's fabric (Fleras, 2019). The nation's commitment to kindness and leadership is evident in its

efforts to promote social cohesion and ensure equal opportunities for all its citizens (Kagedan, 2020). However, despite these commendable efforts, bullying remains a pervasive issue, undermining the very principles Canada espouses (Campbell, 2021). Considering these complexities, this research seeks to undertake a descriptive qualitative systematic narrative review to demonstrate the dynamics of bullying among Black youth in Ontario. By exploring the multifaceted interplay between bullying, mental health, and well-being within this demographic, this study seeks to not only highlight existing challenges but also to inform targeted interventions and policies aimed at fostering a more inclusive and supportive environment for all youth in Ontario.

2. Historical Background

Bullying is the most common form of youth violence that has raised concerns for students, parents, teachers and mental health establishments alike, considering its physical, emotional, and psychological impacts. Several studies have shown that bullying among children and adolescents contribute to severe symptoms of mental health issues, especially self-harm, and suicide ideation (Bryson et al., 2021). Considering the growth of the use of the internet among young people, bullying is now diverse in contrast to traditional victimization and physical injuries (Modecki et al., 2014).

Gender, racial or ethnic background, age, socioeconomic background, and personality have been found to be associated with bullying. Without intervention, bullying can lead to significant deterioration of mental health among high school students, which can persist into adulthood (Eyuboglu et al., 2021). Despite the recognition of bullying as a challenge in high schools across Canada, there are no specific provisions in the Criminal Code that prohibit bullying and its exhibition in varying forms like cyberbullying (Public Safety Canada, n.d). However, due to the

wide range of this behaviour, bullying that escalates to the level of criminal conduct is subject to remedies provided in the Criminal Code provisions. For instance, depending on the activity, criminal harassment is catered for by Section 264 of the Criminal Code. Other instances of bullying include incitement of hatred (section 319), intimidation (subsection 423(1)), uttering threats (section 264.1), and false messages (incriminating libel and slander), indecent or harassing telephone calls (section 372) (Government of Canada, n.d.).

2.1 Current Background of the Phenomenon Identified

Historically, Black communities in Ontario have endured systemic racism and discrimination, which manifest in various forms, including unequal access to education, employment, and social services (Williams et al., 2022). These structural inequities exacerbate the challenges faced by Black youth, rendering them more susceptible to bullying and victimization within their schools, neighborhoods, and online spaces. Studies like Xu et al. (2020) have consistently shown that Black youth experience higher rates of bullying compared to their peers from other racial or ethnic backgrounds, which often takes on multiple forms, including verbal harassment, physical aggression, cyberbullying, and microaggressions, all of which can have lasting impacts on their mental health and well-being.

The intersectionality of race, gender, and socio-economic status further exacerbates the vulnerability of Black youth to bullying. For instance, Black girls may experience unique forms of bullying that intersect with gendered stereotypes and expectations, while those from low-income backgrounds may encounter additional challenges in accessing support services or resources to address bullying (Iruka & Hawkins, 2022). Consequently, the rise and increased use of social media and digital technologies has introduced new avenues for bullying and harassment, with Black youth

often targeted for their race or ethnicity in online spaces. In response, there are current efforts to seek action against bullying because it is amplifying the historical injustices of minorities like Black community in Canada. Organizations such as Parents of Black Children (PoBC) work toward common goals of ensuring sustainable, systemic and transformational change in education systems in Ontario. In their analysis of anti-Black racism (PoBC, n.d), PoBC (2022), congruent arguments were presented to the Ontario Human Rights Commission to advocate for Black students regarding anti-oppressive practices and anti-Black racism in the schools.

A 2021 survey conducted by the Angus Reid Institute in collaboration with the University of British Columbia sheds light on the prevalence of racial and ethnic-based bullying among Canadian youth, particularly in school environments. The survey, which gathered responses from 872 Canadian youth aged 12 to 17, revealed concerning statistics regarding the experiences of racial discrimination and exclusion within educational settings (Angus Reid Institute and the University of British Columbia, 2021). In their survey findings, Angus Reid Institute found that a significant portion of Canadian youth, approximately 58%, reported witnessing instances where children were insulted, bullied, or excluded due to their race or ethnicity while at school. Moreover, 14% of the respondents disclosed that they themselves had experienced such mistreatment firsthand.

Notably, the study highlighted disparities in the prevalence of personal abuse based on race, with visible minority children being three times more likely and Indigenous children twice as likely as white children to report facing such incidents. This study developed through collaboration between the Angus Reid Institute and UBC, builds upon previous research efforts aimed at understanding and addressing issues of racism and discrimination in Canada. The insights garnered from the survey contribute to ongoing discussions and initiatives focused on combating anti-Asian racism and other forms of discrimination within Canadian society (Fletcher, 2021).

Sexual and gender differences are also significant considerations in bullying and victimization. According to Prokopenko and Hango (2022), seventy percent of adolescents between the ages of 15 and 17 acknowledged encountering various forms of bullying within the past year. Notably, sexually and gender diverse youth within the same age bracket faced the highest risk, with 77% reporting experiencing at least one of the ten types of bullying behaviors assessed in the survey. In comparison, 69% of cisgender youth, defined as those exclusively attracted to a different gender, reported similar experiences (Prokopenko & Hango, 2022).

2.2 Youth Development Versus The Impact of Bullying Onto Youth

Bullying takes a toll on the mental and emotional well-being of youth, with significant implications for brain development, self-esteem, and overall growth. Research indicates that repeated exposure to bullying behaviors can adversely impact the developing brain, disrupting neural pathways and physiological processes critical for cognitive and emotional functioning. For instance, in their study, D’Urso, Symonds, and Pace (2021) found that experiencing bullying during early adolescence was primarily associated with several factors, including having a smaller social circle, greater family financial strain, and residing in neighborhoods characterized by increased levels of disorder.

During adolescence, a period characterized by rapid brain development and neural plasticity, experiences of bullying can leave lasting imprints on the brain’s structure and function (Gale, 2016). Chronic stress resulting from bullying can trigger dysregulation of the hypothalamic-pituitary-adrenal (HPA) axis, leading to alterations in stress hormone levels, such as cortisol, which in turn can impair neurodevelopmental processes. Moreover, the pre-frontal cortex may be particularly vulnerable to the effects of bullying. Fine and Hayden (2022) explain that the prefrontal cortex is responsible for executive cognitive functions like impulse control, decision-making, and

emotional regulation. Therefore, prolonged exposure to stressors associated with bullying can impede the maturation of this brain region, compromising an individual's ability to navigate social interactions and regulate emotions effectively (Fine & Hayden, 2022).

Significantly, bullying inflicts profound psychological harm, eroding self-esteem and sense of self-worth because victims of bullying often internalize negative perceptions of themselves, attributing blame and inadequacy to their own identities (Fernanda & Carla, 2023). If such a negative self-concept persists into adulthood, it hinders personal growth, interpersonal relationships, and overall well-being. On the other hand, the cumulative effects of bullying extend beyond immediate psychological distress, contributing to long-term mental health issues from depression, anxiety, to post-traumatic stress disorder. The toxic stress induced by bullying can alter neurobiological processes implicated in mood regulation and emotional processing, predisposing individuals to chronic mental health conditions later in life (Palamarchuk & Vaillancourt, 2022).

2.3 Bitter Facts

Bullying has been consistently linked to adverse mental health outcomes such as depression, anxiety, and even suicide (Wolke & Lereya, 2015). It is a very common form of youth violence in Canada and the US, and the interventions available have not managed to curb its growth. An accumulated research body found that 10-30% of adolescents report being bullying victims, while 5-13% admitted to being bullying perpetrators in school (Hong et al., 2022). More often than not, most researchers have generally focused on the effect of bullying on the whole population of young people with less inquiry into specific defining characteristics like race and ethnicity. Sapouna, De Amicis, and Vezzali (2023) support this latter argument by explaining that despite a growing body of research demonstrating that large numbers of minorities experience racist bullying

with regard to their race, ethnic and religious backgrounds, racist bullying only gained attention recently but as a specific bullying sub-type. In an exploration of racial and ethnic differences in bullying, Xu et al. (2020) found that African Americans were more likely to experience frequent verbal, physical and sexual victimization compared to their white and Latino counterparts. Therefore, by using Black high school students as participants, this research aided in understanding how bullying impacts Black students, as the mental health consequences might vary based on cultural and contextual factors.

Sengupta (2019) reports the case of E.H., whose identity was concealed to protect him who was anxious and experienced nightmares because of the bullying he experienced at school. He says that he is always on guard because the racist taunting and threats about harming him scare him. From the n-word calling to escalated physical attacks, E.H. could only stay alert even alone at home. Sengupta (2019) reports that even after a video surfaced of him getting beaten, the perpetrators were only suspended, including him because they didn't listen to him. This seems that the perpetrators often get away with school violence while the victim is victimized even further. For instance, E.H. says that he had five teachers following him at school, which made him look bad.

On the other hand, ignoring the situation seems to indicate supporting the perpetrators. For instance, in Angus Reid Institute and University of British Columbia's (2021) study, they explain that children who have encountered or observed racism within their school environment commonly report that teachers typically attempt to discourage such behavior and address it by speaking to the perpetrators. About 30% indicate that racist actions often lead to disciplinary measures, including punishment, suspension, or detention for the individuals involved. However, a quarter of the

children surveyed express that teachers either overlook racist behavior or are unaware of its occurrence.

In another part of their study, Angus Reid Institute and UBC (2021) found that children from visible minority backgrounds are at a higher risk of encountering racism within the school environment. On the other hand, White students (47%) and Indigenous students (44%) are more inclined to report the absence of such behaviors at their schools compared to visible minority students (30%) (Angus Reid Institute and University of British Columbia, 2021). However, Indigenous students (18%) and visible minority students (26%) are respectively twice and three times as likely as those who do not identify as such (8%) to report experiencing race-based bullying, exclusion, or insults (Angus Reid Institute and University of British Columbia, 2021).

Apart from the individual effects, bullying affects educational outcomes, i.e., it can impact students' educational attainment, and Black students already face educational disparities. In their study, Kibriya, Xu and Zhang (2017) found that bullying victims score at least 0.22 standard deviation, which is lower than their peers in a standardized Math examination. Therefore, this research will explain the connections between bullying, mental health, and academic success and the recommended interventions. Still, there is the need for prevention and intervention and the role various persons can play in managing bullying, may it be policy formulation or change in schools' approach to bullying for complete eradication. In general, there are significant gaps in bullying as a concept that necessitate further exploration in regions with cultural diversity, like Ontario.

Young adults subjected to victimization by bullies are likely to face psychological trauma risks, including loneliness, depression, anxiety and suicide ideation. On the other hand, bullying also affects bullies with mental health disorders. In their study, Källmén and Hallgren (2021) found that the bullied reported more emotional problems, while the bullies reported conduct disorders.

Again, the authors support that school may be an escape for mentally troubled children to express their stress on others. On the other hand, Zhang et al. (2021) associate bullying with social ability and development because it causes decreased self-confidence and self-esteem. Again, victimization can cause antisocial behaviour in adulthood, hence an increased risk for society as some of the personalities will resort to crime in the future.

3. Study Rationale

While a wealth of studies has been done to link the impact of bullying onto Black youth, from a pragmatic standpoint, a lot of efforts are still needed to tackle bullying in Ontario at the present time. This study is necessitated to provide a current picture of most recent findings found in literature regarding prevalence of bullying onto Black youth, as well as strong recommendations to be deducted for wide implementation.

It could be possible that this research study highlights the intersectionality that may be ignored as a result of the attention directed towards racism with movements like Black Lives Matter. In other terms, the focus on systemic discrimination may act as a blanket to divert attention away from Black high school student bullying resulting from sexuality and gender. Morales, Grineski, and Collins (2019) recommend that research consider the intersectionality framework and study gender and race together as opposed to separate mechanisms of power because of the intersectionality that arises from oppression, exclusion, and marginalization. Therefore, in light of the intersectionality, this research will explain how Black high school students may also face intersecting forms of discrimination and bullying, including racial, gender-based, or sexual orientation-related harassment and their implications on their mental health.

4. Aim

The primary aim of this research project is to obtain a deep and current understanding of the adverse effects of bullying on the overall health of youth with a particular emphasis on their mental health status.

Through the use of An Exploratory Descriptive Qualitative Systematic Narrative Review study design, the project aims to produce precise, measurable insights into the prevalence, number, and contributing causes of mental health issues within this particular group, as a result of bullying. Contributing to the creation of focused treatments, networks of support, and knowledgeable policies that can improve the mental health and general well-being of Black youth in Ontario is the ultimate objective.

5. Critique of Literature Review

5.1 Literature Search Strategy

Before the search began, a list of keywords was gathered, which were related to the topic: “the impact of bullying on the mental health and well-being.” These words included: “Bullying impact”, “mental health and well-being”, “Black youth mental health”, “Ontario high schools”, “Ontario”, “qualitative research”, “Descriptive study”, “minority youth”, “psychological effects”, “social support”, “coping mechanisms”, “school environment”, “racial discrimination”, “peer relationships”, “resilience”, and “intervention strategies.” The search methodology included predicted outcomes to capture aspects of mental health including “Adolescent mental health”, “youth mental well-being”, “teenage mental health”, “mental health challenges in adolescents”, “emotional well-being in youth”, “psychological distress in young people”, “mental health disorders in adolescents”, “youth mental health services”, “mental health promotion in youth”,

“mental health stigma in teens”, “peer support in adolescent mental health”, “resilience in youth mental health”, “mental health education for young people”, “early intervention in adolescent mental health”, and “risk factors for youth mental health issues.”

Based on the pre-selected keywords and phrases, a combination of thesaurus search and text-word search was used as applicable. The phrases were broken down into single words related to the research topic to ensure the literature search complements preparation for the research (Haraldstad & Christophersen, 2015). Therefore, the free-text search was combined with the index-text search relevant to Black Youth in Ontario, bullying and mental health.

Considering the research was in English, **multiple bibliographical databases** with English research materials and other resources with mental health information on youths were used. The objective was to obtain a comprehensive and exhaustive literature review with materials published up to 2024. These databases include:

- **Seneca Polytechnic Library Database:**

- **PubMed:** a text-search was conducted on this site. PubMed focuses on biomedical literature, but there are articles related to mental health and well-being. Text search was done in the titles and abstracts of the literature.

- **PsycINFO:** text search was used in combination with thesaurus search using keywords related to bullying, mental health, well-being, and qualitative research.

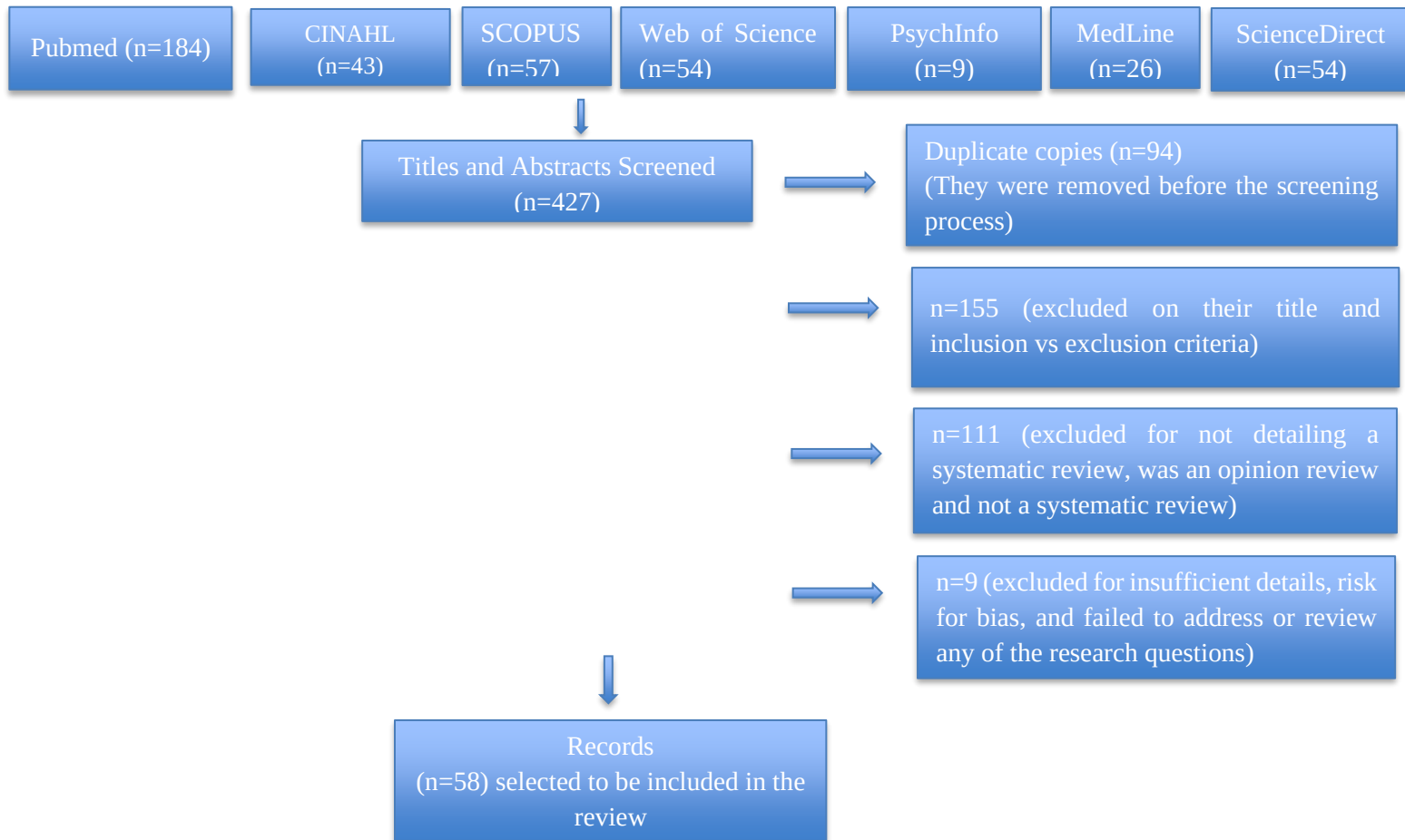
- **Scopus:** text search was used for keywords related to youth bullying and mental health.

- **Google Scholar:** it is freely available to use through word search, and key phrases work best. The word search strategy gives best results because it has a broader range of sources.

Inclusion criteria were: study population (young people, Black), publication date (2014 up to 2024), language (English materials only), and education level (high-school, youth). Papers with variables of interest, i.e., research investigating the relationship between bullying experiences (including prevalence, types, and frequency) and various aspects of mental health and well-being among youth were considered. While the area of focus is Ontario, the literature search extended to the USA, Australia, Netherlands, Sweden, and United Kingdom to examine youths outside the High School environment. At the same time, grey literature from community reports and studies with a descriptive qualitative systematic narrative review study design were included.

Another criterion considered publication types with regard to peer-reviewed journal articles, systematic reviews, meta-analyses, and other scholarly publications that present original research findings and synthesize existing literature on mental health among young people. Mental impact outcomes in these studies were grouped as follows: indicators of psychological well-being (positive affect, life satisfaction, self-esteem, resilience), emotional distress, suicide, self-harm, suicide ideation, and behavioural functioning among individuals experiencing bullying.

5.2 Flow Chart



The inclusion criteria for articles chosen to review in this study encompass literature specifically addressing the intersection of bullying, mental health, and well-being within the context of Black youth in Ontario. These articles are crucial to the study as they provide insights and credibility into the unique challenges and experiences faced by Black youth in Ontario concerning bullying and its impact on their mental health and overall well-being, thereby contributing to a comprehensive understanding of this complex issue.

5.3 Critique of Literature Review

The literature review presented herein is a significant overview of the inquiry into the impact of bullying on the mental health and well-being of Black youth in Ontario.

While each study has unique results, the common themes indicate that bullying has negative impacts on the youths' mental health. Some of these studies show trends in mental health in the described population, while some have provided notable points that contributed to the research.

The methodologies employed in these studies range from Descriptive Studies (surveys, questionnaires) and Qualitative Studies (interviews, focus groups), Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses, which prove validity. Other resources (grey literature) have used policy reviews surveys, statistical reports, annual evaluation reports and case studies.

The limitations in the grey literature include: internal validity and reliability issues, estimation problems, opinion-based and being politicized. On the other hand, the literature sources from scholarly and peer-reviewed materials have a challenge that participants are not randomly sampled because of the nature of the issue under investigation; and due to sampling limitations, there is limited generalizability to the rest of the population, as reflected on contemporary literature as well (Prabhu, 2020).

With the consideration to literature available in regards to bullying in Ontario, the phenomenon is contributing to poor health outcomes among young people (deLara, 2019). In Canada, suicide constitutes 24% of all fatalities among individuals aged 15-24 (Agincourt Community Services Association and Toronto Youth Equity Strategy, n.d.). On the other hand, the stress involved in peer victimization is a long-standing issue that has gained significant recognition. According to Goemans, Viding, and McCrory (2023), there is a distinction between optimum

psychological functioning, like being sad, low-confidence, and distressing states like anxiety and depression and psychological states reflecting what is less than the former.

In 2014, within the youth population of Toronto, 12% of students in grades 7 to 12 disclosed having seriously contemplated suicide within the previous year (City of Toronto, n.d.). A higher percentage of female students (18%) reported such contemplation compared to male students (6%) (City of Toronto, n.d.). Ontario is equally affected as Graham (2020) investigated student mental health and implicated students' voices as the central issue in school-based effects of mental health. Their findings showed that: culture of silence, influenced by gender norms and stigma, significantly affected the mental health of the students in their high school (1), students highlighted several educational practices, both supportive and unsupportive, as having an impact (2), and peer relationships, particularly instances of bullying and involvement in peer-support groups, were identified as both supportive and unsupportive factors affecting the students' mental health (3).

Bullying can also result in enduring damage to self-esteem. Moreover, school bullying can significantly affect the mental well-being of teenagers. In their study, Nazir & Nesheen (2015) explain that experiencing bullying from an early age can have lasting effects that persist into adolescence. Until it is addressed, bullying affects school functioning and adjustment. As a matter of fact, when two groups of adolescents are involved in a study about bullying, there are significant outcomes in their mental health. In Aslan, Allen, and Tanhan's (2021) study, adolescents in both victim and perpetrator groups exhibited notably lower levels of positive psychological outlook, reduced subjective well-being, and increased emotional and behavioural challenges in comparison to their peers who were not involved in such.

A strong link exists between mental health and bullying (Källmén and Hallgren, 2021). Källmén and Hallgren (2021) say the latter is shown to be persisting to late adolescence for young

people bullied in school, leading to mental health problems into early adulthood. Significantly, intersectionality affects the health outcomes for victims of bullying. Using race as part of the intersectional class with youth as the population and bullying as the determining factor, students in the intersectional class are more likely to have higher odds of suicide ideation (Garnett et al., 2014).

The intersectionality can also extend to social status, given Black communities are often among the marginalized communities. However, bullying can turn around for individuals with a higher social status, i.e., if a youth from a higher social status is a perpetrator of bullying at school physically, they may experience online bullying by youths who belong to a less social status (Park et al., 2022).

Bullying is a product of the victimization process with various constructs. Suicidality increases with an increase in victimization frequency as belief-in others decreases (Fullchange & Furlong, 2016). Shireen et al. (2014) found that suicide ideation and suicide rates among young people have been linked to bullying and victimization because the victims are more likely to consider suicide than non-victims as much as 2 to 9 times more. While not extensively researched, harsh parenting and physical punishment are also among risky behaviours that can trigger mental health challenges. WHO (2022) explains that they are also forms of bullying, which is among the leading risks for mental health conditions.

This section entailed reviewed what other studies have discussed about bullying. The results show that the available literature is in consistent agreement with the findings that bullying can lead to increased levels of stress, anxiety, and depression among victims, as well as feelings of isolation and low self-esteem. For instance, (Mayes et al., 2014) has explained that bullying can contribute to the development of mental health disorders and even suicidal ideation or attempts. Strøm et al. (2018) have also stated that although uncommon, the effects of bullying extend beyond the victims,

as perpetrators may also experience negative psychological outcomes such as guilt, shame, and increased aggression. Nevertheless, the inquiry into the impacts of bullying on the mental health of the perpetrators is insufficiently explored.

6. Study Objectives

1. To explore the impact of bullying on the mental health and well-being of Black youth in Ontario.
2. To explore the responsiveness of resources and interventions for Black youth in Ontario.
3. To make meaningful recommendations regarding system changes based on literature review findings
4. To disseminate this research report's highlights amongst interested parties.

7. Study Research Hypothesis and Study Research Questions

7.1 Study Research Hypothesis

I hypothesize that:

- Black youth in Ontario who have experienced bullying will exhibit significantly poorer mental health outcomes, including higher levels of depression and anxiety, compared to their non-bullied peers as seen in the literature under consideration.
- The intersection of race and bullying significantly impacts the mental health of Black youth, leading to unique challenges and consequences beyond what is experienced by students of other racial backgrounds.

7.2 Study Research Questions

- What are the rates of bullying amongst Black youth in Ontario?
- How do they compare to other groups in Ontario?
- What is the extent to which bullying hurts Black youth in Ontario?
- What are the mitigating factors of the effect of bullying unto Black youth?

8. Study Design/Methodology

8.1 Study Design

The study design utilized a Descriptive Qualitative Systematic Narrative Review to describe and characterize the prevalence, number, and contributing causes of mental health issues in Black Youth in Ontario. Descriptive qualitative designs are most preferred because they allow for an exploration of the lived experiences, perceptions, and contextual factors that influence mental health within this specific population, in this context (Hunter, McCallum, & Howes, 2019).

8.2 Qualitative Arm Type

Within the umbrella of a Descriptive Qualitative Study Design, A Systematic Narrative study type was used in this study. The strength of utilizing the arm type is that, by focusing on narratives, we can capture the holistic perspectives of participants and findings (Hunter, McCallum, & Howes, 2019), enabling a comprehensive understanding of the multifaceted nature of mental health challenges faced by Black youth in Ontario, as reflected on the literature identified for review. Additionally, it allows for the contextualization of research findings within the broader social, cultural, and environmental context (Hunter, McCallum, & Howes, 2019) because the author can then present the data in a narrative format to convey the complex interplay of factors

associated with youth mental health.

The Systematic Review component ensures the examination of existing literature where the synthesizing of the findings from multiple studies, helps in identifying common themes, trends, and gaps in knowledge (Xiao & Watson, 2019). This comprehensive approach enhances the validity and reliability of the study's findings, providing a solid foundation for informing interventions and policies. While the design allows for a comprehensive synthesis of existing literature, **it is limited by the availability and quality of published studies.**

8.3 Target Group

The target is studies with the racial element, i.e., Black youth, and location (Ontario). The ultimate goal is to address the impact of bullying onto Black youth, or those who are at risk of bullying and the subsequent mental health challenges.

8.4 Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria

To be eligible for this descriptive study, the studies used were to consider the race aspect in bullying, specifically Black youth. Studies addressed mental health issues among Black youth, including but not limited to depression, anxiety, stress, trauma, substance abuse, self-harm, suicidal ideation, and any other relevant mental health concerns on how they relate to bullying. Both qualitative and quantitative research studies were eligible.

The exclusion criteria included studies that do not directly address mental health issues among Black youth. At the same time, studies focusing on unrelated topics were excluded. For example, studies solely focused on physical health were cut out.

8.5 Sampling Method

The sampling method selected was theoretical sampling (Conlon et al., 2020). The strength of using theoretical sampling is that it leads to in-depth exploration of key concepts and relationships within a phenomenon. However, the iterative nature of the method can lead to complex data analysis processes (Vasileiou et al., 2018).

The selection process of the articles was carried out independently based on the inclusion and exclusion criterion provided. Studies were identified via databases. The total number of studies were 427 (n=427): PubMed (n=184), CINAHL (n=43), SCOPUS (n=57), Web of Science (n=54), MedLine (n=26), ScienceDirect (n=54), PsychInfo (n=9). Duplicate copies (n=94) were removed before they were screened, while those excluded at this stage based on their title and inclusion vs exclusion criteria were 155. 111 articles were excluded for not detailing a systematic review as shown in the flow chart. The remainder were assessed for eligibility and (n=9) were excluded at this stage for insufficient details, risk for bias, failure to address or review any of the research questions. The final number of articles used for this study were 58.

8.6 Safest Sample Size

After considering all processes from considering the content, full-text, database, and language as explained in the sampling method, only 12 studies were considered the safest. This was based on the minimum of 10 articles aligning with the topic of study. The selection of the studies considered the ROBIS tool for reviews because it compares overall risk of bias across selected reviews and allow for comparison and contrast of the studies' findings (Whiting *et al.*, 2016).

8.7 The Recruitment Strategy

A comprehensive search strategy with strict consideration to the inclusion and exclusion criteria was considered. The search was conducted independently by the researcher, therefore eliminating a possibility of disagreements during the selection process. All studies that are considered as systematic reviews, involved bullying, discussed mental health among young people, and those published in English were recruited for the study. These studies were evaluated so as to be aligned with my sample sizing method to ensure the study achieves anticipated saturation (Vasileiou et al., 2018).

8.8 Duration of Data Collection

The process of collecting articles that meet the inclusion criteria lasted between January to March 2024.

8.9 Mitigating Biases

The selected study design is prone to bias (Doyle et al., 2020), but the researcher developed a comprehensive search strategy that includes multiple databases, gray literature sources, and supplementary search methods to identify as many relevant sources as possible and minimize the risk of publication bias. Considering the outlining of the inclusion and exclusion criteria and recommended databases, all studies were subjected to the complete process. The primary research used a range of techniques to mitigate bias in conducting this kind of research as: keeping organized notes, conducting a preliminary categorization of themes identified (Mackieson, Shlonsky, & Connolly, 2019).

8.10 Data Collection Instrument

In descriptive qualitative research, the primary researcher is the main research instrument, who adheres to high quality research conducting guidelines (Johnson, Adkins, & Chauvin, 2020). The researcher uses annotated bibliographies, as they were created in this study, to systematically organize and summarize the features and outcomes of the studies.

8.11 Data Recording

The references were initially managed using Microsoft Excel then transferred to a Microsoft Word Document on 25th February.

8.12 Copyright Protection

This research work is protected by copyright laws regarding publishing, distribution and displaying in various formats in Canada. All rights reserved to the student has the exclusive right to reproduce, distribute, perform, or display the research, subject to certain limitations and exceptions outlined in the Copyright Act (Justice Laws, n.d).

8.13 Methodological Rigour

The process of selecting studies for inclusion in the review was transparent and reproducible as expected in the Descriptive Qualitative search conducting field (Snyder, 2019), and as demonstrated in this body of this study. This study also considered a Systematic Literature Search with respect to the inclusion and exclusion criteria. At the same time, the choice of study design, i.e., a Descriptive Qualitative Systematic Narrative Review was the appropriate to avoid limiting factors like trauma associated with bullying if quantitative elements sought responses from victims.

8.14 Data Storage

Data collected on the resources selected is stored in Microsoft Excel, where access is guaranteed to the primary user of the account. The entire study material is also stored and protected in electronic devices which are double password protected, even though the Tri-Council Policy Statement: Ethical Conduct for Research Involving Humans (TCPS 2), does not apply to this study design (Millum, 2012).

8.15 Mitigation of Adverse Events During the Study

There are no known in the selected study design. Only readily available research was used and all copyright provisions were observed accordingly, and the primary researcher accounted for any unexpected setbacks during the conducting of this research study.

8.16 Ethical and Legal Statement

Even though the ethical guidelines outlined by the Tri-Council Policy Statement: Ethical Conduct for Research Involving Humans (TCPS 2 (Millum, 2012) developed by the Canadian Institutes of Health Research (CIHR) and the Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada (SSHRC) (SSHRC, n.d) do not apply to this study, the primary research attests conducting it in the most ethical and rigorous way. Additionally, measures were kept in consideration regarding anonymization of data obtained from included studies to protect the privacy of the participants, if this occurred to be the case.

This section has provided a description of the design, inclusion and exclusion criteria, sampling, data collection, and the recruitment strategy which provide a systematic outline of the

research content. At the same time, it has shown the data collection and storage process that guarantees confidentiality in the data collected. The study design section is important because the information obtained is used in the subsequent step in discussing the results and findings.

9. Results/Findings and Discussion in Relation to Study Hypothesis and Study Research

Questions

A range of key themes were identified in the articles which were summarized in Table 1.

Table 1: Bullying and its associated impacts on youth mental health based on identifying features and social location

Themes	Sub-Themes	Citation
Bullying based on social status (socio-economic background)	- Bullying can turn around for individuals with a higher social status. - Youth from lower socio-economic background are at a higher risk for bullying. - Youth bullied based on their social status (socioeconomic background) have poor mental health outcomes due to inaccessibility to resources.	Sapouna et al. (2020) Xu et al. (2020) Park et al. (2022) Zhang et al. (2021)
Bullying based on identifying features	- Racial minorities are more likely to be bullied. - Black youths belong to both perpetrator	Sapouna et al. (2020) Xu et al. (2020) Sapouna, De Amicis, and Vezzali (2023)

	and victim groups and both end up with mental health. - White youth are less likely to be bullied based on their race.	Angus Reid Institute and the University of British Columbia (2021) Strøm et al. (2018)
Bullying and victimization are more likely to result in poor mental health outcomes.	- Suicide ideation - Self-esteem - Social function - Anxiety and depression - Cyberbullying causes paranoia and suicide Ideation.	Shireen et al. (2014) Mayes et al. (2014) (Fullchange & Furlong, 2016) Strøm et al. (2018) Guo, Tan, and Zhu (2022) Stewart-Tufescu et al. (2021) Kwan et al. (2020) Xu et al. (2020)

9.1 Results

8 articles out of 12 (68%) were published between 2020 and 2023. Overall, all the studies discussed bullying due to the racial background and mental health. Only 2 out of 12 (25%) articles considered family-level factors with regard to their influence on bullying. Most of these studies were conducted in North America (Canada and USA), Australia and Europe.

9.1.1 The Rates of Black Youth Bullying

Research Question: What are the Rates of Bullying Amongst Black Youth in Ontario?

9 studies addressed the prevalence of bullying across racial lines. 7 reviews discussed the

prevalence of bullying among the youth and the intersectionality with race and ethnicity. 2 studies found that racial minorities were more likely to be victims of bullying due to their race (Sapouna et al., 2020). One study conducted estimated rates of youth bullying and reported a probability of 46% for Black youth bullying (Xu et al., 2020). Sapouna, De Amicis, & Vezzali (2023) also seemed to be comprehensive on bullying on minority and the intersection involved. However, Sapouna, De Amicis and Vezzali, (2023) reported that the evidence regarding the correlation between experiencing bullying stemming from racial, ethnic, or religious prejudice and poverty is inconclusive. Cabrera (2019) found that ethnic identity serves as a distinguishing factor in the occurrence of harassment, particularly among individuals with low socio-economic status and cultural backgrounds, which may contribute to increased tendencies toward depression and substance abuse among those targeted for ethnic-based harassment.

This study section has reported that instances of derogatory name-calling and racially charged insults emerged as the prevailing forms of racist bullying, consistently highlighted across all focus groups and recognized as a significant issue by school administration, educators, and students.

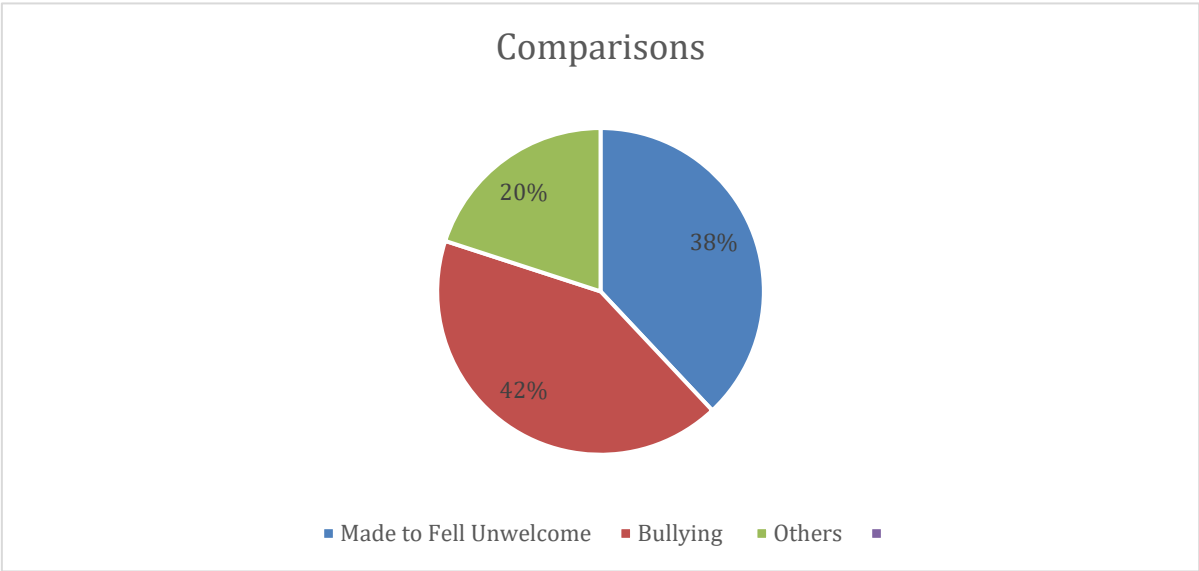
9.1.2 Comparison with Other Groups

Research Question: How do They Compare to Other Groups in Ontario?

Xu et al. (2020) reported that African American students ($OR = 1.27$) demonstrated a higher likelihood of being categorized into the group characterized by frequent experiences of verbal, physical, and sexual victimization compared to White and Latino students ($OR = 0.82$), among the four distinct latent classes identified (including occasional verbal and physical victimization, verbal and sexual victimization, and no victimization).

A study by Angus Reid Institute and the University of British Columbia (2021) found that approximately half (54%) of respondents indicate that children engage in name-calling or insults rooted in racial or ethnic backgrounds at their school. Comparatively smaller percentages report instances where children feel unwelcome (38%) or are subjected to bullying (42%) based on their racial or ethnic background.

Figure 3: Percentage comparisons



9.1.3 Extent of Harm

Research Question: What is the Extent to Which Bullying Hurts Black Youth in Ontario?

Table 2: Impact of bullying

Source	Information
Ye et al. (2023)	Bullying poses a risk of depression among children and adolescents.
Ashrafi et al. (2023)	Findings indicated that three categories of students who experienced victimization: those

	subjected to aggressive victimization (7.2%); those subject to moderate victimization (34.6%); and those who did not report victimization (58.2%). Younger age and overweight status were linked to an increased likelihood of being bullied. Ashrafi et al. (2023) also reported that moderately and aggressively victimized students exhibited higher chances of feeling alienated, experiencing anxiety, depression, suicidal thoughts, and engaging in alcohol consumption compared to non-victimized students.
Kupilik (2022)	Any reported engagement in bullying, whether as a victim or perpetrator, is associated with thoughts of suicide. Particularly, individuals identified as both bullies and victims have an elevated risk of experiencing suicidal thoughts.

9.1.3.1 Gender Differences

Based on their selected model, Kim et al. (2022) found that there were differences although not significant in bullying and psychological impacts. The figures below represent this information.

Figure 2: Impacts on Boys: Age 15

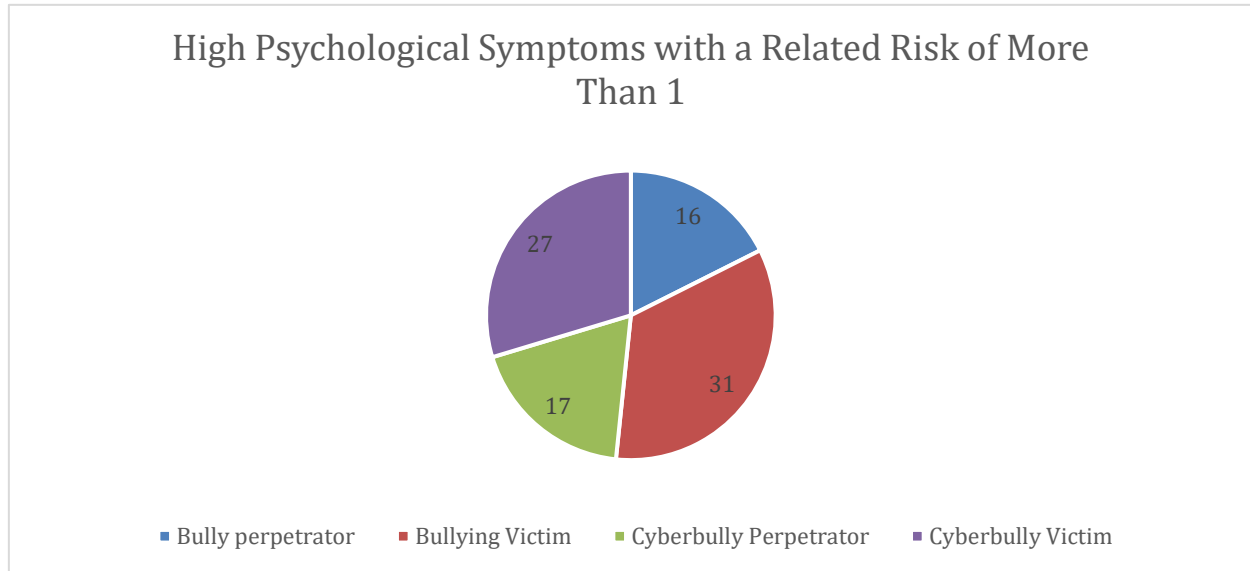
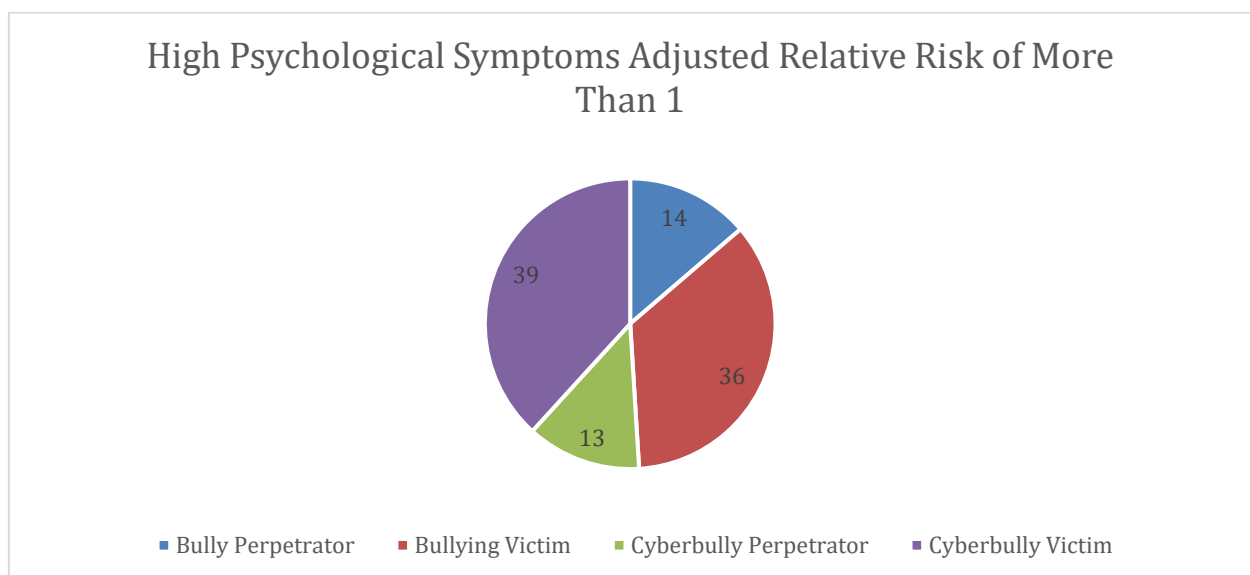


Figure 4: Impacts on Girls: Age 15



9.1.4 Mitigating Factors

Research Question: What are the mitigating factors of the effect of bullying unto Black youth?

One study included the mitigation strategies (Colizzi, Lasalvia, & Ruggeri, 2020). Colizzi, Lasalvia, and Ruggeri (2020) contend that research indicates that expecting mental health professionals solely to manage promotion and prevention efforts in mental health would be impractical. Instead, Colizzi, Lasalvia, & Ruggeri (2020) explain there is a growing consensus that integrated and multidisciplinary approaches are necessary to expand intervention options and mitigate the likelihood of unfavorable long-term outcomes. This approach may also yield advantages in terms of reducing healthcare system expenditures (Colizzi, Lasalvia, & Ruggeri, 2020). Nonetheless, Colizzi, Lasalvia, and Ruggeri (2020) say mental health professionals bear the scientific, ethical, and moral obligation to guide the various social, political, and healthcare entities engaged in addressing mental health needs during adolescence.

9.2 Discussion of Findings

The studies above have shown that bullying, particularly when it is racially motivated or targeted, can have profound and lasting effects on the mental health and overall well-being of youths and most likely extend into adulthood. Research has shown that racialized youth are disproportionately targeted for bullying based on their race or ethnicity, experiencing higher rates of name-calling, racial slurs, and other forms of racially motivated harassment compared to their peers. This persistent exposure to racism and discrimination can lead to feelings of isolation, low self-esteem, and psychological distress among them.

One significant aspect of the impact of bullying on mental health is its prevalence. Studies

like Xi et al. (2020) indicate that a substantial proportion of racialized youth report experiencing bullying at some point during their school years. This prevalence highlights the urgent need for effective prevention and intervention strategies to address the issue.

9.3 Data Analysis Method

This study systematically extracted relevant qualitative data from included studies identified through the systematic review process, analyzed the extracted qualitative data using thematic analysis techniques, and synthesized the extracted data into a coherent narrative that provides a rich description.

9.4 Limitations of this Study

This study has the following limitations:

Initially, the primary research papers eliminated several reviews that did not primarily target youth, were published before the last decade, lacked specification of systematic review methodology, or were published in languages other than English. It was recognized that this approach may lead to the exclusion of certain systematic reviews and their corresponding findings.

Additionally, since the primary researcher exclusively considered peer-reviewed journal publications, there exists a potential for publication bias, where studies presenting positive results are more inclined to be published. Lastly, there was limited literature focusing on Ontario, which led to generalization of results from other locations, with implications for adoption in Ontario as well.

9.5 Possible Implications of Study

This study has implications for mental health and addiction, especially on health promotion and prevention. Therefore, the findings can inform the development of evidence-based policies and interventions aimed at addressing bullying and promoting mental health among Black youth in Ontario, including implementing anti-bullying programs, enhancing cultural sensitivity and diversity training for educators and school staff.

At the same time, it raises awareness about the unique experiences and vulnerabilities of Black youth with regards to bullying and mental health to facilitate advocacy efforts in prioritizing the needs of Black youth in anti-bullying initiatives and mental health services across Ontario.

9.6 Dissemination of the Findings

The findings herein will be disseminated in the form of a PowerPoint presentation, which will pick on the key points only. This presentation is part of the fulfilment of the Seneca Polytechnic's recommended Capstone Project. Additionally, this study's results will be published under the Mobilization Hub of Seneca Polytechnic, with encouragement for further academic dissemination in outside academic circles. Hopefully, the results will communicate to learners, policymakers, and the public health field.

Nonetheless, this section has helped discuss the results from the studies included in the review. It is significant to drawing conclusions and implications to practice.

10. Conclusion

This narrative review has explored the issue of bullying among the youth at the rise of internet and other enabling tools. The researcher has cited other authors who have explored topics

related to bullying and the subsequent impacts on mental health. Significantly, the study has potential in highlighting the disparities in access to mental health care and support services for Black youth to inform efforts to improve access to culturally competent and inclusive mental health services. One of the significant shortcomings has been generalizability of a majority of studies obtained for the review.

As a recommendation for future direction, the researcher sees fit that human based research be conducted on Black Youth in Ontario to create a rich literature source for future researchers. Nevertheless, the researcher has highlighted the history of the issue, which professionals can pick when developing interventions like clear legal remedies for bullying as opposed to the current ambiguous provisions.

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